

EMPLOYMENT AND TRAINING ADMINISTRATION ADVISORY SYSTEM U.S. DEPARTMENT OF LABOR Washington, D.C. 20210	CLASSIFICATION
	VISION FOR THE ONE-STOP SYSTEM
	CORRESPONDENCE SYMBOL ETA OWI
	DATE August 13, 2015

**ADVISORY: TRAINING AND EMPLOYMENT GUIDANCE LETTER WIOA NO: 4-15
OPERATING GUIDANCE for the WORKFORCE INNOVATION AND
OPPORTUNITY ACT (WIOA or Opportunity Act)**

TO: STATE AND LOCAL STAKEHOLDERS IN THE WORKFORCE
INNOVATION AND OPPORTUNITY ACT
STATE WORKFORCE ADMINISTRATORS
STATE WORKFORCE LIAISONS
STATE AND LOCAL WORKFORCE BOARD CHAIRS AND DIRECTORS
AMERICAN JOB CENTER DIRECTORS
SECTION 166 INDIAN AND NATIVE AMERICAN GRANTEEES

FROM: PORTIA WU /s/
Assistant Secretary

SUBJECT: Vision for the One-Stop Delivery System under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA)

- Purpose.** This Training and Employment Guidance Letter (TEGL) lays out the vision for the one-stop delivery system under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) and links to key technical assistance resources to support states and local areas as they integrate this vision into their one-stop delivery system (<http://www.doleta.gov/wioa>). This guidance is also being issued by the Department of Education's Office of Career, Technical, and Adult Education and Office of Special Education and Rehabilitation Services. It was developed in collaboration with these agencies, as well as the Department of Health and Human Services, Administration for Children and Families. The Employment and Training Administration (ETA) will soon issue additional guidance to other programs administered by DOL that covers governance, operational, and service delivery topics related to the one-stop delivery system.

WIOA was signed into law on July 22, 2014. WIOA is designed to help job seekers access employment, education, training, and support services to succeed in the labor market and to match employers with the skilled workers they need to compete in the global economy. WIOA supersedes titles I and II of the Workforce Investment Act of 1998 (WIA), and amends the Wagner-Peyser Act and the Rehabilitation Act of 1973.

RESCISSIONS None	EXPIRATION DATE Continuing
----------------------------	--------------------------------------

The Departments of Labor and Education published a set of proposed regulations for implementing WIOA through the posting of five Notice of Proposed Rulemaking (NPRMs) documents. These NPRMs were open for public comment until June 15, 2015, and thousands of comments were received by both Departments. The Federal agencies will review, analyze, consider, and respond to the comments received. The Final WIOA rules will be issued in 2016.

In order to continue implementation prior to the final rule, a series of WIOA Operating Guidance documents are being issued in the form of Training and Employment Guidance Letters (TEGLs). These Operating Guidance documents on WIOA will inform the workforce system on how to begin the important planning and organizational work necessary to comply with the WIOA statutory requirements. The Operating Guidance TEGLs will provide a framework for program activities until the regulations are finalized. This TEGL is one in a series of WIOA Operating Guidance.

2. **References.** See Attachment.
3. **Background.** The vision for the one-stop delivery system contained in this TEGL reflects the long-standing and ongoing work of dedicated workforce professionals around the country to align a wide range of publicly- and privately-funded education, employment, and training programs while also providing high-quality customer service to job seekers, workers, and businesses through the one-stop delivery system.

The creation of one-stop centers (currently branded as American Job Centers) was a cornerstone of WIA when it passed in 1998. In the years between the passage of WIA and WIOA—and longer for those communities that piloted one-stop centers under the Job Training Partnership Act of 1982—the workforce system has tested a variety of approaches to maximize the benefits of one-stop centers to its direct customers and their communities. In the last 10 years, technological advancements have opened up new avenues of service delivery, and the increased availability of evidence-based models has strengthened our shared understanding of the best of these approaches. In addition, the Obama Administration worked intensively with federal agencies in 2013 and 2014 to reform federal employment, education, and training programs to create a more integrated, job-driven service delivery system. A job-driven service delivery system is one that results in linking our nation's diverse talent with employers and businesses. As a result of this work, one-stop centers continue to be a valued community resource, known both locally and nationally as an important source of assistance for those looking for work or workers, and those looking for opportunities to grow their careers.

WIOA recognizes the value of the one-stop delivery system, and provides the workforce system with important tools to enhance the quality of its one-stop centers. The law strengthens the ability of States, regions, and local areas to align investments in workforce, education, and economic development to regional in-demand jobs. It also places greater emphasis on achieving results for job seekers, workers, and businesses. Finally, it reinforces the partnerships and strategies necessary for one-stop centers to provide job seekers and workers with the high-quality career services, education and training, and the supportive services they need to obtain good jobs and stay employed; and to help businesses find skilled

workers and access other supports, including education and training for their current workforce.

Since the one-stop delivery system was established, technology has made lasting changes to our economy and society. Mobile workers and businesses with regional and national footprints that cross municipal borders are much more common. For that reason, there is an increased customer demand for consistent, high-quality education, employment, and training services across the country. The passage of WIOA supports the workforce system in meeting that demand, and the adoption of a national vision for the one-stop delivery system and its one-stop centers is an important first step in that work.

4. **Vision for the One-Stop Centers under WIOA.** The publicly funded workforce system envisioned by WIOA is quality-focused, employer-driven, customer-centered, and tailored to meet the needs of regional economies. It is designed to increase access to, and opportunities for, the employment, education, training, and support services that individuals need to succeed in the labor market, particularly those with barriers to employment. It aligns workforce development, education, and economic development programs with regional economic development strategies to meet the needs of local and regional employers, and provide a comprehensive, accessible and high-quality workforce development system. This is accomplished by providing all customers access to high-quality one-stop centers that connect them with the full range of services available in their communities, whether they are looking to find jobs, build basic educational or occupational skills, earn a postsecondary certificate or degree, or obtain guidance on how to make career choices, or are businesses and employers seeking skilled workers.

Under WIOA, partner programs and entities that are jointly responsible for workforce and economic development, educational, and other human resource programs collaborate to create a seamless customer-focused one-stop delivery system that integrates service delivery across all programs and enhances access to the programs' services. The one-stop delivery system includes six core programs (Title I adult, dislocated worker, and youth programs; Title II adult education and literacy programs; Title III Wagner-Peyser program; and Title IV vocational rehabilitation program), as well as other required and optional partners identified in WIOA¹. Through the one-stop centers, these partner programs and their service providers

¹ In addition to the core programs, required partners include the Senior Community Service Employment Program; job counseling, training, and placement services for veterans authorized under chapter 41 of title 38; career and technical postsecondary education programs authorized under the Carl D. Perkins Career and Technical Education Act of 2006; Trade Adjustment Assistance Programs; employment and training activities carried out under the Community Services Block Grant; U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) employment and training programs; Unemployment Compensation programs; programs authorized under the Second Chance Act of 2007, Section 212 (reintegration of ex-offenders); and programs authorized under the Social Security Act Title IV, Part A (TANF), unless the Governor determines that TANF is not a required partner.

Optional partners may include, with the approval of the local board and chief elected officials, the U.S. Social Security Administration (SSA) employment and training program (i.e. Ticket to Work programs); Supplemental Nutrition and Assistance Program (SNAP) employment and training programs; the Vocational Rehabilitation Client Assistance Program; National and Community Service Act Programs; and other employment, education or training programs such as those operated by libraries or in the private sector.

ensure that businesses and job seekers—a shared client base across the multiple programs identified above—have access to information and services that lead to positive employment outcomes. Under WIOA, one-stop centers and their partners:

- provide job seekers with the skills and credentials necessary to secure and advance in employment with family-sustaining wages;
- provide access and opportunities to all job seekers, including individuals with barriers to employment, such as individuals with disabilities, to prepare for, obtain, retain, and advance in high-quality jobs and high-demand careers;
- enable businesses and employers to easily identify and hire skilled workers and access other supports, including education and training for their current workforce;
- participate in rigorous evaluations that support continuous improvement of one-stop centers by identifying which strategies work better for different populations;
- ensure that high-quality integrated data inform decisions made by policy makers, employers, and job seekers.

The management of the one-stop delivery system is the shared responsibility of States, local boards, elected officials, the core WIOA partners, other required partners, and one-stop center operators. The Departments encourage all of these entities to integrate the characteristics below into their work, including developing state, regional, and local strategic plans; establishing one-stop center certification criteria; examining the state, regional, and local footprint of one-stop centers; conducting competitions for selecting one-stop center operators; developing local Memoranda of Understanding (MOUs); updating other one-stop center policies and procedures; and operating and delivering services through the one-stop centers.

5. **Characteristics of a High-Quality One-Stop Center.** The characteristics identified below, consistent with the purpose and authorized scope of each of the programs, are designed to reflect elements that the Departments believe contribute to a high-quality one-stop delivery system. They demonstrate the spirit and intent of WIOA, and the Departments believe they will strengthen the successful integration and implementation of partner programs in one-stop centers. For clarity and readability the characteristics have been grouped into three functional categories: (a) Customer Service; (b) Innovation and Service Design; and (c) Systems Integration and High-Quality Staffing.

- a. **One-Stop Centers Provide Excellent Customer Service to Job Seekers, Workers and Businesses.** Meeting the needs of job seekers, workers and businesses is important in developing thriving communities where all citizens succeed and businesses prosper. High-quality one-stop centers:

- **Reflect a welcoming environment to all customer groups who are served by the one-stop centers.** All one-stop center staff are courteous, polite, responsive, and helpful to job seekers, businesses, and others who visit the one-stop centers, either in person or by telephone or e-mail. Moreover, one-stop center staff are sensitive to the unique needs of individuals with disabilities and are prepared to provide necessary accommodations.

- **Develop, offer, and deliver quality business services** that assist specific businesses and industry sectors in overcoming the challenges of recruiting, retaining, and developing talent for the regional economy. To support area employers and industry sectors most effectively, one-stop center staff identify and have a clear understanding of industry skill needs, identify appropriate strategies for assisting employers, and coordinate business services activities across one-stop center partner programs, as appropriate. This includes the incorporation of an integrated and aligned business services strategy among one-stop center partners to present a unified voice for the one-stop center in its communications with employers. Additionally, one-stop centers use the forthcoming performance measure(s) on effectiveness in serving employers to support continuous improvement of these services.
- **Improve the skills of job seeker and worker customers.** One-stop centers offer access to education and training leading to industry-recognized credentials through the use of career pathways, apprenticeships, and other strategies that enable customers, including those with disabilities, to compete successfully in today's global economy. They provide businesses with access to the quantity and quality of talent they need and support upskill/backfill strategies that expand job opportunities in the community.
- **Create opportunities for individuals at all skill levels and levels of experience** by providing customers, including those with disabilities, as much timely, labor market, job-driven information and, choice as possible related to education and training, careers, and service delivery options, while offering customers the opportunity to receive both skill-development and job placement services.
- **Provide career services that motivate, support and empower customers,** including individuals with disabilities, to make informed decisions based on local and regional economic demand and effectively attain their personal employment and education goals.
- **Value skill development** by assessing and improving each individual's basic, occupational, and employability skills.

b. One-Stop Centers Reflect Innovative and Effective Service Design. High-quality one-stop centers:

- **Use an integrated and expert intake process for all customers entering the one-stop centers.** Frontline staff are highly familiar with the functions and basic eligibility requirements of each program, and can appropriately assist customers and make knowledgeable referrals to partner programs, as needed and as appropriate given the authorized scope of the program.
- **Design and implement practices that actively engage industry sectors** and use economic and labor market information, sector strategies, career pathways,

Registered Apprenticeships, and competency models to help drive skill-based initiatives.

- **Balance traditional labor exchange services with strategic talent development** within a regional economy. This includes use of market-driven principles and labor market information that help to define a regional economy, its demographics, its workforce and its assets and gaps in skills and resources.
- **Ensure meaningful access to all customers.** One-stop centers must be physically and programmatically accessible to all customers, including individuals with disabilities. In so doing, one-stop centers use principles of universal design and human-centered design, such as flexibility in space usage; the use of pictorial, written, verbal and tactile modes to present information for customers with disabilities or limited English proficiency; providing clear lines of sight to information for seated or standing users; providing necessary accommodations; and providing adequate space for the use of assistive devices or personal assistants. One-stop centers use assistive technology and flexible business hours to meet the range of customer needs.
- **Include both virtual and center-based service delivery** for job seekers, workers, and employers. Both methods of delivery support the talent needs of the regional economy, although each may better serve different customers with different levels of service needs at any given time. The one-stop delivery system can expand its reach by delivering robust virtual services; and increasing the accessibility of those services through community partners, such as libraries, community and faith-based organizations, and other partners.
- **Incorporate innovative and evidence-based delivery models** that improve the integration of education and training, create career pathways that lead to industry-recognized credentials, encourage work-based learning, and use state-of-the-art technology to accelerate learning and promote college and career success.

c. **One-Stop Centers Operate with Integrated Management Systems and High-Quality Staffing.** High-quality one-stop centers:

- **Reflect the establishment of robust partnerships among partners.** The one-stop center operator facilitates an integrated, co-located partnership that seamlessly incorporates services of the core partners and other one-stop center partners.
- **Organize and integrate services by function** (rather than by program); when permitted by a program's authorizing statute and as appropriate, and by coordinating staff communication, capacity building, and training efforts. Functional alignment includes having one-stop center staff who perform similar tasks serve on relevant functional teams, e.g. Skills Development Team, Business Services Team. Service integration focuses on serving all customers seamlessly (including targeted

populations) by providing a full range of services staffed by cross-functional teams, consistent with the purpose, scope, and requirements of each program.

- **Develop and maintain integrated case management systems** that inform customer service throughout the customer's interaction with the integrated system and allow information collected from customers at intake to be captured once. Customer information is properly secured in accordance with personally identifiable information guidelines, and facilitated as appropriate, with the necessary memoranda of understanding or other forms of confidentiality and data sharing agreements, consistent with federal and state privacy laws and regulations. Data, however, would be shared with other programs, for those programs' purposes, within the one-stop system only after the informed written consent of the individual has been obtained, where required.
 - **Develop and implement operational policies** that reflect an integrated system of performance, communication, and case management, and use technology to achieve integration and expanded service offerings.
 - **Use common performance indicators** to ensure that federal investments in employment and training programs are evidence-based, labor market driven, and accountable to participants and taxpayers. Center performance is transparent and accountable to the communities and regions served; data entry staff are trained and understand the importance of data validation, data collection processes, and the importance of accurate reporting.
 - **Train and equip one-stop center staff** in an ongoing learning process with the knowledge, skills, and motivation to provide superior service to job seekers, including those with disabilities, and businesses in an integrated, regionally focused framework of service delivery. Center staff are cross-trained, as appropriate, to increase staff capacity, expertise, and efficiency. Cross-training allows staff from differing programs to understand every program and to share their expertise about the needs of specific populations so that all staff can better serve all customers. Center staff are routinely trained and are keenly aware as to how their particular function supports and contributes to the overall vision of the local board.
 - **Staff the center with highly trained career counselors**, skilled in advising job seekers of their options, knowledgeable about local labor market dynamics, aware of available services inside and outside the one-stop center, and skilled in developing customers' skills for employment success.
6. **Resources.** Along with the resources provided at the WIOA collections page at <http://wioa.workforce3one.org>, the following technical assistance tools are currently available as part of the Departments' ongoing effort to support state and local areas in the adoption of the vision for the one-stop centers under WIOA.

a. Provide Excellent Customer Service to Job Seekers, Workers and Employers.

- Opening Doors for Everyone: Providing Outstanding Customer Service at One-Stop Career Centers: This toolkit is designed to provide one-stop center staff members an enhanced level of comfort when providing service to customers with a diverse array of backgrounds and needs.
<https://wioa.workforce3one.org/view/2001501480321360042/info>
- Expanding Business Engagement: WIOA makes significant changes to the nation's workforce development system, expressly incorporating the sector strategies approach throughout and requiring regional planning and alignment with local labor market needs for in-demand sectors and occupations. The Expanding Business Engagement (EBE) - Technical Assistance (TA) Initiative will support the strategic planning and implementation of revitalized or enhanced business engagement activities within states, regions, and local areas.
<http://businessengagement.workforce3one.org/>

b. Reflect Innovative and Effective Service Design.

- One-Stop Service Design: The resources section contains a variety of curated technical assistance tools, best practices, replicable models, implementation plans, recorded webinars, videos, research documents, and data reports to support innovative and effective one-stop center service design.
<https://wioa.workforce3one.org/ws/wioa/pages/resources.aspx?pparams=1001501462393639983>
- Legacy Disability Training: Understanding Disability: The purpose of this introductory course is to provide practical learning experience toward acquiring the knowledge and skills needed to provide quality workforce development services to persons with disabilities.
<https://wioa.workforce3one.org/view/4011507054815454755/info>

c. Integrated Administrative Systems and High Quality Staffing.

- Integrated Service Delivery Toolkit: This toolkit provides ideas, strategies and resources for integrating service delivery in the public workforce system.
<https://wioa.workforce3one.org/view/2001508963127430705/info>
- Effective Case Management: This site contains resources and tools designed to help system administrators, local leaders and staff to support high-quality case management in the workforce system.
<https://effectivecasemanagement.workforce3one.org/index.aspx>

d. Other One-Stop Vision Technical Assistance Tools.

- One-Stop Career Centers Fact Sheet: Provides highlights of WIOA reforms for one-stop centers. <https://wioa.workforce3one.org/view/2001507734890961606/info>
- Quick Start Action Plan (QSAP) for One-Stop Centers: An interactive, self-paced assessment tool designed to help leaders at all levels of the public workforce system prepare for implementation of WIOA. The QSAP helps identify areas of strength and focused areas for improvement in a state or local workforce system and connects to targeted resources that can help leaders to prepare and plan effectively. <http://qsap.workforce3one.org/page/planner/OneStop/Questionnaire>

7. **Action Requested.** As WIOA core programs and partners at the state and local level implement WIOA in program year 2015, the Departments encourage states to adopt this vision and build it into the policies and procedures related to the management of the one-stop delivery system. This includes developing regional and local strategic plans; establishing certification criteria for one-stop centers and the one-stop delivery system; examining the state, regional, and local footprint of one-stop centers; conducting competitions for selecting one-stop center operators; developing the local MOU; and updating other one-stop center policies and procedures.
8. **Inquiries.** Please direct questions regarding this guidance to the appropriate ETA Regional office or through the ETA email address established for this purpose: DOL.WIOA@dol.gov. ETA monitors this account daily, and may respond to inquiries directly or through general communications such as official guidance, webinars, and public Q&A documents.
9. **Attachment.** References for the One-Stop Vision TEGL